



Above New Orleans hosts a renowned spring jazz festival, but live music energizes the city throughout the year

Left Tall, three-story Creole houses, with shallow wrought-iron balconies, are typical of the French Quarter of New Orleans



Above Like its name, which fuses French and African influences, jambalaya brings together ingredients as diverse as seafood and game

What Else to Eat

Gumbo is the Creole answer to bouillabaisse and may be seasoned with *file*, a Native American spice made from dried, ground sassafras leaves, and served over white rice. **Etouffée** is a thicker stew typically made of crawfish, though shrimp, crab, or chicken can also be used, cooked in a roux with vegetables and spices. **Red beans and rice** is a typical New Orleans dish that may be served with grilled fish “blackened” with a coating of spices. **Po’boy** sandwiches of fried seafood or meat on foot-long baguettes are classic New Orleans street food, as are **beignets**, square doughnuts covered in powdered sugar.

The Best Places to Eat Jambalaya

K-Paul’s Louisiana Kitchen

expensive

Chef Paul Prudhomme is a Louisiana legend, the first chef to make New Orleans food respectable to the modern gourmet diner. His Louisiana Kitchen is now a city landmark, and though the atmosphere is casual café-style, the food is upmarket, the quality superb, and reservations essential. The restaurant building dates from 1834, with dining rooms on both floors, and alfresco tables in the atmospheric courtyard or on the balcony in season. Prudhomme uses only fresh ingredients, so the menu changes daily. Appetizers might include a cup of his chicken and *andouille* gumbo, made with his own *andouille* sausages; turtle soup; or his own inimitable version of Cajun jambalaya, simmered for hours in a rich stock with just the right amount of rice. The main-course temptations might feature another classic, crawfish *étouffée* – a stew simmered with the lid on, or “smothered” – or an eggplant pirogue (the name for a Cajun canoe) deep-fried and filled with Bay scallops, Louisiana shrimp, and crawfish.

416 Chartres Street, French Quarter, New Orleans;
open 11 AM–2 PM Thu–Sat, 5:30 PM–10 PM
Mon–Sat; www.kpauls.com

Also in New Orleans

You can sample the Creole version of jambalaya at **Mr. B’s Bistro** (www.mrbsbistro.com; *expensive*), where dishes like gumbo ya-ya, seafood gumbo, and Gulf shrimp with grits offer more tastes of the Creole south. Come for the Sunday Jazz Brunch, when a jazz trio lends a festive air. **The Gumbo Shop** (www.gumboshop.com; *inexpensive*) offers an atmospheric taste of old New Orleans, from its faded decor to the long menu of Creole and Cajun favorites.

Also in the US

For authentic New Orleans food and atmosphere in southern Florida, head to **Jambalaya Jeb’s** (<http://jambalayajeb.com>; *inexpensive*) in Bonita Springs. This simple place in the Flamingo Island Flea Market is run by a family from Louisiana. They love the home cooking they grew up with and make their jambalaya, gumbo, and other dishes fresh each day and serve tasty New Orleans-style beignets.

Around the World

In the southern hemisphere, **South Restaurant** (www.south-restaurant.com; *moderate*) brings Creole cuisine to Sydney, Australia. Dishes include Creole jambalaya, gumbo, crawfish *étouffée*, and the traditional New Orleans muffuletta sandwich – a round loaf filled with salami, cheese, ham, and garlic, topped with an olive salad – which owes its origins to Sicilian immigrants to New Orleans.